

Ordinary Mind and the Rhetoric of Immediacy

1. The problem

Zen repeatedly says the Way is not elsewhere: no special state, no external Buddha, no final doctrine to grasp. Bernard Faure calls attention to the rhetoric of immediacy: a tradition can deny mediation while relying on teachers, texts, ritual forms, institutions, bodies, and lineage. The contradiction disappears only if 'immediacy' is treated as a rhetorical and soteriological claim rather than a literal description of social organization.

2. Two bad inferences

First: 'because awakening is immediate, historical forms do not matter.' Second: 'because historical forms mediate Zen, immediacy is a fraud.' Both are too fast. A practice can use highly mediated forms to undermine a student's tendency to reify those forms. The right question is which mediations are denied, which are retained, and how the tradition marks the difference.

3. A test for 'ordinary'

Suppose two interpretations compete. A says ordinary mind means unedited spontaneity. B says it means activity no longer divided by grasping into sacred practice and profane life. B better explains why Zen institutions can call ordinary activities practice while still regulating conduct with exceptional precision. An interpretation earns weight by explaining more evidence, not by sounding more paradoxical.

4. Keep for later

Encounter dialogue, koan practice, shikantaza, and modern claims of 'just this' will all reuse the promise of immediacy. Each time, ask what apparatus makes that immediacy teachable. The apparatus is not outside Zen. It is one of the things Zen historically is.

Three considerations

- 1 Anti-text rhetoric is textual evidence. A saying that dismisses words reaches us because a community wrote, edited, copied, and taught it. That does not refute the saying, but it makes textual mediation part of the phenomenon.
- 2 Spontaneity can be cultivated. A response that looks unpremeditated may depend on years of ritual, doctrinal, literary, and interpersonal training. Learned fluency is not the opposite of spontaneity.
- 3 Immediacy is socially authorized. The same gesture can count as awakening, insolence, error, or noise depending on who performs it, before whom, and within what lineage. Claims of immediacy therefore have institutional conditions even when their content denies dependence on external certification.

Method

Bernard Faure's critique is most useful when it prevents a false choice. We need not decide that Zen is either pure ineffable experience or nothing but rhetoric and power. The better question is how rhetoric, embodied practice, literary form, and institution cooperate to make a kind of immediacy intelligible. That question preserves the possibility that practice changes experience while refusing to treat the language used to describe that change as transparent.

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